

Monitoring: The Three-Layer Reference

Day 5 handout. A monitoring plan has three layers, each answering a different question for a different audience. The goal across all three: fire before users notice.

LAYER	AUDIENCE	RHYTHM	THE QUESTION IT ANSWERS
On-call alerts	Engineers on rotation	Real-time	"Is something on fire right now?"
Operator dashboards	TPM, eng lead, SREs	Daily / weekly	"Is the system trending the right way?"
Executive dashboards	Leadership	Weekly / monthly	"Are we meeting our SLOs / KPIs / NS?"

What each layer holds

On-call alerts — 3–5 alerts per feature (more = noise). Each passes the four-question test (see the alert-design template).

Operator dashboard — what a TPM looks at every Monday morning. Cap at **< 6 charts**:

- Top-line metric (the SLO you care most about)
- Operational signals trending
- Alert volume / mute reasons
- Any deferrals from the previous week

Executive dashboard — what leadership sees in the weekly review. Cap at **< 4 charts**:

- The NS-relevant operational signal (from the Tier Sheet)
- The KPI the feature is meant to move
- Status: green / yellow / red against SLOs

The discipline

- Operator dashboards over 6 charts go unread. Prioritize ruthlessly.
- Track **mute reasons** at the operator level — that's where the alert-tuning conversation lives.